

Cairn

Barebones Edition



Intro

Cairn: Barebones Edition is an adventure game about traversing underground tunnels, decrepit castles, dark forests, and other dreadful places. Character creation is entirely random and fast, exploration is tense and rewarding, and combat is chaotic and lethal. The rules and procedures included here match those in the Cairn Second Edition Player's Guide, but this version removes the implied setting and structured creation process. Much like the original Cairn, it retains full compatibility with Cairn Second Edition adventures but offers an even more minimal, flexible framework for old-school play. For examples of play, a reliquary, a complete bestiary, and much more, download the Warden's Guide at <https://cairnnp.com/>!

Table of Contents

Overview & Principles 3

Core Rules 6

Procedures..... 13

Character Creation 24

Gear Packages36

Marketplace37

Spellbooks 40

Character Sheet47

Credits

Writing by Yochai Gal

Editing by Derek B.

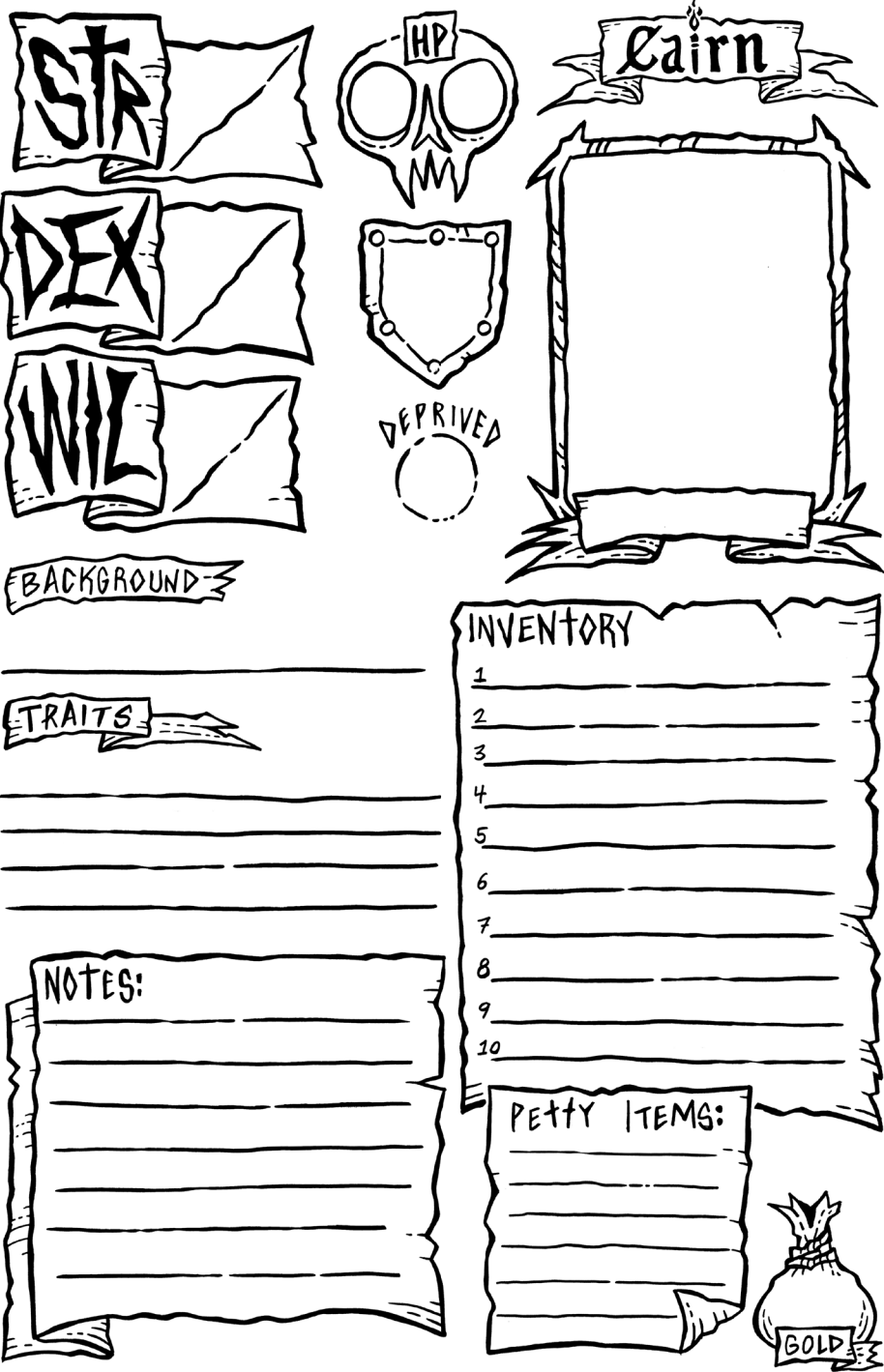
Layout by Adam Hensley

Cover Art by Amanda Lee Franck

Character Sheet by Skullfungus

Published by Cairn Press

Cairn Barebones Edition • Version 1.0.0. • Feb 2026 • Text is CC BY-SA 4.0



90	Thicket	A thicket of trees and dense brush up to 50ft wide suddenly sprouts up. <i>Wrapped in vines that must be destroyed again with each use.</i>
91	Time Control	Time in a 50ft bubble slows down or increases by 10% for 30 seconds. <i>Alternates its appearance as either impossibly old or freshly written.</i>
92	True Sight	You see through all nearby illusions. <i>Cannot be concealed by magic, and sticks out like a sore thumb.</i>
93	Upwell	A spring of seawater appears. <i>Hardened leather bindings caked in salt and living barnacles.</i>
94	Vision	You completely control what a creature sees. <i>An unnerving, lidless eye graces the front cover.</i>
95	Visual Illusion	A silent, immobile, room-sized illusion of your choice appears. <i>Filled with rich, colorful pages very much like a children's bedtime story.</i>
96	Ward	A silver circle 50ft across appears on the ground. Choose one species that cannot cross it. <i>The covers are decorated with bizarre, otherworldly creatures with thousands of eyes.</i>
97	Web	Your wrists shoot thick webbing. <i>The text is alien, yet somehow intelligible, for it is the language of dreams.</i>
98	Widget	A primitive version of a drawn tool or item appears before you and disappears after a short time. <i>Smells of iron and rust, sweat and effort. Faint sounds of harsh labor emanate from deep within its pages.</i>
99	Wizard Mark	Your finger can shoot a stream of ulfire-colored paint. This paint is only visible to you and can be seen at any distance, even through solid objects. <i>Inside the front cover is a small pocket containing a thin pad of paper, listing the name and date of death of all previous owners.</i>
100	X-Ray Vision	You can see through walls, dirt, clothing, etc. <i>Long-term exposure can cause hair loss, blurry vision, and fatigue.</i>

Overview & Principles

Overview

Neutrality

The Warden's role is to act as a neutral arbiter and portray the rules, situations, non-player characters (NPCs), and narrative clearly.

Classless

A character's role or skills are not limited by a single class. Instead, the equipment they carry and their experiences define their specialty.

Death

Characters may be powerful, but they are also vulnerable to harm in its many forms. Death is always around the corner, but it is never random or without warning.

Fiction First

Dice do not always reflect an obstacle's difficulty or its outcome. Instead, success and failure are based on in-world elements and arbitrated by the Warden in dialogue with the players.

Growth

Characters are changed through in-world advancement, gaining new skills and abilities by surviving dangerous events and overcoming obstacles.

Player Choice

Players should always understand the reasons behind the choices they've made, and information about potential risks should be provided freely and frequently.

Principles

The Warden and the players each have guidelines that help foster a specific play experience defined by critical thinking, exploration, and an emergent narrative.

Shared Objectives

Players trust one another to engage with the shared setting, character goals, and party challenges. Therefore the party is typically working together towards a common goal, as a team.

Principles for Players

Agency

- Attributes and related saves do not define your character. They are tools.
- Don't ask only what your character would do; ask what you would do, too.
- Be creative with your intuition, items, and connections.

Teamwork

- Seek consensus from the other players before barreling forward.
- Stay on the same page about goals and limits, respecting each other and accomplishing more as a group than alone.

Exploration

- Asking questions and listening to detail is more useful than any stats, items, or skills you have.
- Take the Warden's description without suspicion, but don't shy away from seeking more information.
- There is no single correct way forward.

Talking

- Treat NPCs as if they were real people, and rely on your curiosity to safely gain information and solve problems.
- You'll find that most people are interesting and will want to talk things through before getting violent.

Caution

- Fighting is a choice and rarely a wise one; consider whether violence is the best way to achieve your goals.
- Try to stack the odds in your favor, and retreat when things seem unfavorable.

Planning

- Think of ways to avoid your obstacles through reconnaissance, subtlety, and fact-finding.
- Do some research, and ask around about your objectives.

Ambition

- Set goals, and use your meager means to take steps forward.
- Expect nothing. Earn your reputation.
- Keep things moving forward, and play to see what happens.

75	Shuffle	Two creatures you can see instantly switch places. <i>If stolen but not yet read, it reappears wherever its owner last left it.</i>
76	Skillful Repair	You make minor repairs to a nonliving object. <i>Sewn from the vellum of one hundred books, no two pages are alike.</i>
77	Sleep	A creature you can see falls into a light sleep. <i>Soft as a pillow, but yields only fitful sleep.</i>
78	Slick	Every surface in a 30ft radius becomes extremely slippery. <i>Gloves are required for handling, lest the book is dropped in a most comical fashion.</i>
79	Smoke Form	Your body becomes a living smoke that you can control. <i>Smells of campfire. The pages cannot be burnt, but are very sensitive to moisture.</i>
80	Sniff	You can smell even the faintest traces of scents. <i>Expresses a strong odor detectable only by its owner.</i>
81	Snuff	The source of any mundane light you can see is instantly snuffed out. <i>If left in one place for long periods, nearby light sources eventually dim, then finally go out.</i>
82	Sort	Inanimate items sort themselves according to categories you set. <i>Rights itself when dropped or thrown.</i>
83	Spellsaw	A whirling blade flies from your chest, clearing any plant material in its way. It is otherwise harmless. <i>Wrapped in stained leather, it should be oiled at least once a month.</i>
84	Spider Climb	You can climb surfaces like a spider. <i>New cobwebs must be pushed aside prior to each use. They are hard to remove.</i>
85	Swarm	You become a swarm of crows, rats, or piranhas. You can only be harmed by <i>blast</i> attacks. <i>Easily broken into a dozen distinct parts that slowly move towards one another over time.</i>
86	Target Lure	An object you touch becomes the target of any nearby spell. <i>Attracts all manner of magical creatures, spell leaks, and scrying.</i>
87	Telekinesis	You may mentally 1 move item under 60lbs. <i>The owner can summon the book through mental command alone (WIL save or become deprived afterwards).</i>
88	Telepathy	Two creatures can hear each other's thoughts, no matter how far apart. <i>The holder can hear (but not respond) to the thoughts of whoever last possessed it, and vice versa.</i>
89	Teleport	An object or person you can see is transported from one place to another in a 50ft radius. <i>Can be destroyed to create a portal to another dimension.</i>

61	Passage	Creates a temporary path through wood, stone or brick. <i>An object dropped on top of the book inevitably falls through the other side.</i>
62	Phobia	A nearby creature becomes terrified of an object of your choice. <i>Over time, haunting, abstract art begins to fill its pages.</i>
63	Pit	A pit 10ft wide and 10ft deep opens in the ground. <i>A standard piton can be safely stored in its spine.</i>
64	Primal Surge	A creature rapidly evolves into a future version of its species. <i>The owner is haunted by strange visions of their own ancestors.</i>
65	Push/Pull	An object of any size is pulled directly towards you or pushed directly away from you with the strength of one man. <i>Any force against the book is comically amplified.</i>
66	Raise Dead	A skeleton rises from the ground to serve you. They are incredibly stupid and can only obey simple orders. <i>The owner becomes more and more fascinated with bones after each use.</i>
67	Raise Spirit	The spirit of a nearby corpse manifests and will answer 1 question. <i>The answers (but not their questions) are forever inscribed in its pages.</i>
68	Read Mind	You can hear the surface thoughts of nearby creatures. <i>Long-term possession can cause the reader to mistake the thoughts of others as their own.</i>
69	Repel	Two objects are strongly magnetically repelled from each other within 10 feet. <i>Closed by two powerful straps that spring open at inopportune times.</i>
70	Scry	You can see through the eyes of a creature you touched earlier today. <i>The owner's eyes turn milky-white for an hour after use.</i>
71	Sculpt Elements	Inanimate material behaves like clay in your hands. <i>Slowly decays on contact with wood or cloth. Bury in dirt or submerge in water to refresh.</i>
72	Sense	Choose one kind of object (key, gold, arrow, jug, etc). You can sense the nearest example. <i>The book's previous owner is always aware of the book's current location.</i>
73	Shield	A creature you touch is protected from mundane attacks for one minute. <i>Bound in rusty ring-mail and is quite heavy. If held, provides +1 Armor.</i>
74	Shroud	A creature you touch is invisible until they move. <i>Invisible to any but the book's current owner.</i>

Principles for Wardens

Information

- Provide useful information about the game world as the characters explore it.
- Players do not need to roll dice to learn about their circumstances.
- Be helpful and direct with your answers to their questions.
- Respond honestly, describe consistently, and always let them know they can keep asking questions.

Difficulty

- Default to context and realism rather than numbers and mechanics.
- If something the players want to do is sincerely impossible, no roll will allow them to do it.
- Is what the player describes and how they leverage the situation sensible? Let it happen.
- Saves cover a great deal of uncertain situations and are often all that is necessary for risky actions.

Preparation

- The game world is organic, malleable and random. It intuitively makes sharp turns.
- Use random tables and generators to develop situations, not stories or plots.
- NPCs remember what the PCs say and do, and how they affect the world.
- NPCs don't want to die. Infuse their own self-interest and will to live into every personality.

Narrative Focus

- Emergent experience of play is what matters, not math or character abilities. Give the players weapon trainers and personal quests to facilitate improvement and specialization.

- Pay attention to the needs and wants of the players, then put realistic opportunities in their path.
- A dagger to your throat will kill you, regardless of your expensive armor and impressive training.

Danger

- The game world produces real risk of pain and death for the player characters.
- Telegraph serious danger to players when it is present. The more dangerous, the more obvious.
- Put traps in plain sight and let the players take time to figure out a solution.
- Give players opportunities to solve problems and interact with the world.

Treasure

- A Treasure is specific to the environment from where it is recovered. It tells a story.
- Treasure is highly valuable, almost always *bulky*, and rarely useful beyond its worth and prestige.
- Relics are not Treasure, though they are useful and interesting.
- Use Treasure as a lure to exotic locations under the protection of intimidating foes.

Choice

- Give players a solid choice to force outcomes when the situation lulls.
- Use binary "so, A or B?" responses when their intentions are vague.
- Work together using this conversational method to keep the game moving.
- Ensure that the player character's actions leave their mark on the game world.

Core Rules

Player Characters

Attributes

Player Characters (PCs) have three Attributes:

- **Strength (STR):** Used for saves requiring physical power, like lifting gates, bending bars, resisting poison, etc.
- **Dexterity (DEX):** Used for saves requiring poise, speed, reflexes, dodging, climbing, sneaking, balancing, etc.
- **Willpower (WIL):** Used for saves to persuade, deceive, interrogate, intimidate, charm, provoke, manipulate spells, etc.

Attributes are not universal descriptors. A character with a low STR is not necessarily hopelessly weak; they can still attempt to lift a heavy door or survive a deadly fight! Their risk is simply higher.

Attribute Loss

- If a PC takes damage outside of combat, they should instead receive damage to an Attribute, typically STR.
- If a PC's STR is reduced to 0, they die. If their DEX is reduced to 0, they are paralyzed. If their WIL is reduced to 0, they are delirious. Complete DEX and WIL loss renders the character unable to act until they are restored through extended rest or by extraordinary means.

Hit Protection

- Hit Protection (HP) reflects a character's ability to avoid damage in combat.
- This measurement does not indicate a character's health or fortitude, nor do they lose it for very long. See Healing & Recovery.

Healing & Recovery

- Resting for a few moments and having a drink of water restores lost HP but may leave the party exposed. Bandages can stabilize a character that has taken critical damage.
- Attribute loss (see Critical Damage) can usually be restored with a week's rest, facilitated by a healer or other appropriate source of expertise.
- Some healing services are free, while magical or more expedient means of recovery may come at a cost.

46	Knock	A nearby mundane or magical lock unlocks loudly. <i>Locked. A new owner “produces” the key after their next meal.</i>
47	Leap	You jump up to 10ft high, once. <i>When thrown, it just keeps going.</i>
48	Liquid Air	The air around you becomes swimmable. <i>Floats of its own volition, bouncing off of whatever it touches.</i>
49	Magic Dampener	All nearby magical effects have their effectiveness halved. <i>Relics within 100ft of the spellbook cannot be recharged.</i>
50	Manse	A sturdy, furnished cottage appears for hours. You can permit and forbid entry to it at will. <i>If left inside, both the book and the cottage vanish forever.</i>
51	Marble Craze	Your pockets are full of marbles and will refill every 30 seconds. <i>When jostled, makes a playful rattling sound.</i>
52	Masquerade	A character's appearance and voice becomes identical to those of a character you touch. <i>Extended use causes the owner to develop unconscious yet noticeable tics.</i>
53	Miniaturize	A creature you touch is shrunk down to the size of a mouse. <i>The text is ludicrously, comically large.</i>
54	Mirror Image	An illusory duplicate of yourself appears and is under your control. <i>Over time, the owner begins to question who is the original, and who is the duplicate.</i>
55	Mirrorwalk	A mirror becomes a gateway to another mirror that you looked into today. <i>Will not open unless the owner politely knocks on the cover.</i>
56	Multiarm	You temporarily gain an extra arm. <i>After use, the caster is wracked with phantom limb syndrome for a day.</i>
57	Night Sphere	A 50ft-wide sphere of darkness displaying the night sky appears before you. <i>Displays a prominent constellation on its cover.</i>
58	Objectify	You become any inanimate object between the size of a grand piano and an apple. <i>The owner experiences intense pareidolia for days after use.</i>
59	Ooze Form	You become a living jelly. <i>Slowly drips an acid that eventually eats away anything it touches.</i>
60	Pacify	A creature near you has an aversion to violence. <i>Smells of jasmine and incense. Attracts children.</i>

31	Flare	A bright ball of energy fires a trail of light into the sky, revealing your location to friend or foe. <i>Faintly glows in complete darkness.</i>
32	Fog Cloud	A dense fog spreads out from you. <i>When submersed in water, the book eventually turns all the liquid to vapor.</i>
33	Frenzy	A nearby creature erupts in a frenzy of violence. <i>Rough, sandpaper cover that destroys any book it touches.</i>
34	Gate	A portal to a random plane opens. <i>A large hole is carved into the center, ending in a void. Items dropped within are never seen again.</i>
35	Gravity Shift	You can change the direction of gravity, but only for yourself. <i>Attaches itself to the largest object nearby.</i>
36	Greed	A creature develops the overwhelming urge to possess a visible item of your choice. <i>The cover changes depending on the owner, subtly hinting at their deepest desires.</i>
37	Haste	Your movement speed is tripled. <i>Pages flip wildly while open. Can cause paper cuts.</i>
38	Hatred	A creature develops a deep hatred of another creature or group and wishes to destroy them. <i>Long term exposure to the book can cause suspicion, paranoia and distrust of others.</i>
39	Hear Whispers	You can hear faint sounds clearly. <i>The reader's voice is amplified for a short period of time afterwards.</i>
40	Hover	An object hovers, frictionless, 2ft above the ground. It can hold up to one humanoid. <i>Floats if dropped.</i>
41	Hypnotize	A creature enters a trance and will truthfully answer one yes or no question you ask it. <i>Eye-catching, swirling spirals don its covers.</i>
42	Icy Touch	A thick ice layer spreads across a touched surface, up to 10ft in radius. <i>Gloves required. Nonflammable.</i>
43	Identify Owner	Letters appear over the object you touch, spelling out the name of the object's owners, if there are any. <i>The book's interior lists the name of its previous owner.</i>
44	Illuminate	A floating light moves as you command. <i>When held in light, the pages become a prism of vibrant rainbows.</i>
45	Invisible Tether	Two objects within 10ft of each other cannot be moved more than 10ft apart. <i>Its pages are not attached by glue or thread, yet stay together nonetheless.</i>

Armor

- Before calculating damage to HP, subtract the target's Armor value from the result of damage rolls.
- Shields and similar armor provide a bonus defense (e.g. +1 Armor), but only while the item is held or worn. Some may also provide additional benefits, depending on the fiction.
- A PC, NPC, or monster cannot have more than 3 Armor.

Inventory

- Characters have a total of ten inventory slots but can only carry four or five items comfortably without the help of bags, backpacks, horses, carts, etc.
- Each PC starts with a Backpack that can hold up to six slots of items or Fatigue. Carts (which must be pulled with both hands), horses, or mules can make a huge difference in how much a PC can bring with them on an adventure. Hirelings can also be paid to carry equipment.
- Inventory is abstract, dependent only on the fiction as adjudicated by the Warden. Anyone carrying a full inventory (i.e. filling all 10 slots) is reduced to 0 HP. A character cannot fill more than ten slots.

Inventory Slots

- Most items take up one slot unless otherwise indicated.
- *Petty* items do not take up any slots. *Bulky* items take up two slots.
- A bag of coins worth less than 100gp is *petty* and does not occupy a slot.

Deprivation & Fatigue

- A PC that lacks a crucial need (such as food or rest) is *Deprived*. Anyone *Deprived* for more than a day adds Fatigue to their inventory, one for each day. A *Deprived* PC cannot recover HP, Attributes, or item slots from Fatigue.
- A PC may also be forced to add Fatigue after casting spells or due to events occurring in the fiction. Each Fatigue occupies one slot and lasts until the PC is able to recuperate (such as with a full night's rest in a safe spot).
- If a character is forced to add Fatigue to their inventory but they have no free slots, they must drop an item from their inventory.

Saves & Risk

Saves

- A save is a roll to avoid negative outcomes from risky choices. Characters roll a d20 and compare the results to the appropriate attribute. If they roll equal to or under that attribute, they succeed. Otherwise, they fail. A 1 is always a success, and a 20 is always a failure.
- If two opponents are each trying to overcome the other, whoever is most at risk should save.
- If two characters need to take an action together, whoever is most at risk should save (usually the character with the lowest relevant Attribute).

Die of Fate

- Optionally, roll 1d6 whenever the outcome of an event is uncertain or to simulate an element of randomness and chance.
- A roll of 4 or more generally favors the PCs, while a roll of 3 or under usually means bad luck for the PCs.

Non-Player Characters

Hirelings

- Adventuring parties can recruit hirelings, relying on their unique skills, knowledge, and training to aid in expeditions.
- To create a hireling, choose an appropriate role from the Hirelings table in the Marketplace. Roll 3d6 for each attribute and 1d6 for their HP. Give them equipment appropriate to their station, then roll on the Character Traits tables to further flesh them out.
- Alternatively, follow the Character Creation process but select the appropriate background, name, and gear for the character.

Reactions

- When the PCs encounter an NPC whose reaction to the party is not obvious, the Warden may roll 2d6 and consult the following table:

Reactions				
2	3-5	6-8	9-11	12
Hostile	Wary	Curious	Kind	Helpful

15	Command	A target obeys a single three-word command that does not cause it harm. <i>Grows thinner over time, until finally disappearing forever.</i>
16	Comprehend	You become fluent in all languages for a short while. <i>Drips letters, staining whatever it touches.</i>
17	Cone of Foam	Dense foam sprays from your hand, coating the target. <i>Spongy and moist with a soapy residue.</i>
18	Control Plants	Nearby plants and trees obey you and gain the ability to move at a slow pace. <i>Leaves grow along the spine, and it smells faintly of decay.</i>
19	Control Weather	You may alter the type of weather at will, but you do not otherwise control it. <i>Highly resistant to fire and water damage.</i>
20	Cure Wounds	Restore 1d4 STR per day to a creature you can touch. <i>Smells of vinegar and thyme. Turns red after use.</i>
21	Deafen	All nearby creatures are deafened. <i>Nearby instruments occasionally sound off, as if in protest.</i>
22	Detect Magic	You can see or hear nearby magical auras. <i>Becomes warm to the touch if magic is used nearby.</i>
23	Disassemble	Any of your body parts may be detached and reattached at will, without causing pain or damage. <i>You can still control them. Regenerates any torn or defaced pages.</i>
24	Disguise	You may alter the appearance of one character at will as long as they remain humanoid. Attempts to duplicate other characters will seem uncanny. <i>The surface makes a perfect mirror.</i>
25	Displace	An object appears to be up to 15ft from its actual position. <i>Bits of string, clothing, and leaves are sometimes stuffed inside.</i>
26	Earthquake	The ground begins shaking violently. Structures may be damaged or collapse. <i>Sand dribbles from the corners, seemingly without stop.</i>
27	Elasticity	Your body can stretch up to 10ft. <i>Smells of taffy, and is very flexible.</i>
28	Elemental Wall	A straight wall of ice or fire 50ft long and 10ft high rises from the ground. <i>Skin and warmer substances stick to it after use.</i>
29	Filch	A visible item teleports to your hands. <i>An ally's prized possession may occasionally be found tucked between its covers.</i>
30	Fish Lung	A target can breathe underwater until they surface again. <i>Smells strongly of the sea. Attracts wild animals.</i>

Spellbooks

1	Adhere	An object is covered in extremely sticky slime. <i>Adjacent objects stick to the book with great force.</i>
2	Anchor	A strong wire sprouts from your arms, affixing itself to two points within 50ft on each side. <i>If a rope is pulled through the iron loop on its spine, it becomes as heavy as an elephant.</i>
3	Animate Object	An object obeys your commands as best it can. Moldable like clay. Childish laughter sprouts from its pages.
4	Anthropomorphize	An animal either gains human intelligence or human appearance for one day. <i>Whimpers, purrs and growls depending on its treatment.</i>
5	Arcane Eye	You can see through a magical floating eyeball that flies around at your command. <i>Needs a spritz of water to open.</i>
6	Astral Prison	An object is frozen in time and space within an invulnerable crystal shell. <i>Silent, abstract, faces scream in anguish within.</i>
7	Attract	Two objects are strongly magnetically attracted to each other if they come within 10 feet. <i>Nearby compasses spin uselessly.</i>
8	Auditory Illusion	You create illusory sounds that seem to come from a direction of your choice. <i>Produces random and occasionally inopportune sounds throughout the day.</i>
9	Babble	A creature must loudly and clearly repeat everything you think. It is otherwise mute. <i>When the text is read aloud, the words of others become unintelligible.</i>
10	Bait Flower	A plant sprouts from the ground that emanates the smell of decaying flesh. <i>Attracts flies.</i>
11	Beast Form	You and your possessions transform into a mundane animal. <i>Covered in thick fur, its edges lined with small teeth.</i>
12	Befuddle	A creature of your choice is unable to form new short-term memories for the duration of the spell. <i>Its contents shift and change each time it is opened.</i>
13	Body Swap	You switch bodies with a creature you touch. If one body dies, the other dies as well. <i>The front cover shows an image of the last creature to read it.</i>
14	Charm	A creature you can see treats you as a friend. <i>Warm to the touch, and smells of roses.</i>

Magic

Spellbooks

- Spellbooks contain a single spell and take up one slot. They cannot be easily transcribed or created; instead they are recovered from places like tombs, dungeons, and manors.
- Spellbooks sometimes display unusual properties or limitations, such as producing a foul or unearthly smell when opened, possessing an innate intelligence, or being legible only when held in moonlight.
- Spellbooks will attract the attention of those who seek the arcane power within, and it is considered dangerous to display them openly.

Casting Spells

- Anyone can cast a spell by holding a Spellbook in both hands and reading its contents aloud. They must then add a Fatigue to inventory.
- Given time and safety, PCs can enhance a spell's impact (e.g., affecting multiple targets, increasing its power, etc.) without any additional cost.
- If the PC is *deprived* or in danger (such as during combat), the Warden may require a PC to make a WIL save to avoid any ill-effects from casting the spell. Consequences of failure are on par with the intended effect and may result in added Fatigue, the destruction of the Spellbook, injury, and even death.

Scrolls

Scrolls are similar to Spellbooks, however:

- They are *petty*.
- They do not cause Fatigue.
- They disappear after one use.

Relics

Relics are items imbued with a magical spell or power. They do not cause Fatigue. Relics usually have limited use, as well as a Recharge condition.

Combat

Rounds

- A Round is roughly ten seconds of in-game time and proceeds with each side taking turns. Each round starts with any PC that is able to act, followed by their opponents. The result of each side's actions occur simultaneously.
- During the first round of combat, each PC must make a DEX save in order to act. Special circumstances, abilities, items, or skills may negate this requirement. PCs that fail their save lose their turn for this round.
- Their opponents then take their turn, and the first round ends. The next round begins with the PCs taking their turn, followed by their opponents, and so on until combat has ended with one side defeated or fled.

Actions

On their turn, a character may move up to 40ft and take up to one action. This may be casting a spell, attacking, moving for a second time, or some other reasonable action. Each round, the PCs declare what they are doing before dice are rolled. If a character attempts something risky, the Warden calls for a save for appropriate players or NPCs.

Attacking & Damage

- The attacker rolls their weapon die and subtracts the target's armor, then deals the remaining total to their opponent's HP. Attacks in combat automatically hit.
- If multiple attackers target the same foe, roll all damage dice and keep the single highest result. All actions are declared before being resolved.
- If an attack would take a PC's HP exactly to 0, refer to the Scars table to see how they are uniquely impacted.

Attack Modifiers

- If fighting from a position of weakness (such as through cover or with bound hands), the attack is *Impaired*, and the attacker must roll 1d4 damage regardless of the attack's damage die. Unarmed attacks always do d4 damage.
- If fighting from a position of advantage (such as against a helpless foe or through a daring maneuver), the attack is *Enhanced*, allowing the attacker to roll 1d12 damage instead of their normal die.
- Attacks with the *Blast* quality affect all targets in the noted area, rolling separately for each affected character. This can be anything from explosions to a dragon's breath or the impact of a meteorite. If unsure how many targets can be affected, roll the related damage die for a result.
- If attacking with two weapons at the same time, roll both damage dice and keep the single highest result (denoted with a plus symbol, e.g. d8+d8).

Gear

Air Bladder	5	Gloves (<i>petty</i>)	20
Antitoxin	20	Grappling Hook	25
Bandages (3 uses)	30	Lantern	10
Bathing Goods (Soap, Perfume, etc.)	5	Mirror	5
Book	50	Net	10
Caltrops	10	Oil Can (6 uses)	10
Card Deck	5	Outdoor Comfort (Blanket, Hammock, etc.)	10
Chain (10ft)	10	Parchment (3 uses)	10
Chalk (<i>petty</i>)	1	Pole (10ft)	5
Chest	25	Repellent (Wolfsbane, Mugwort, etc.)	10
Chisel	5	Rope (25ft)	5
Common Agents (Glue, Grease, etc.)	10	Sedative	30
Common Tools (Hammer, Shovel, etc.)	10	Sewing Kit	20
Compass	75	Simple Instruments (Pipes, Lute, etc.)	10
Complex Instruments (Bagpipes, Fiddle, etc.)	50	Smoking Pipe (<i>petty</i>)	15
Containers (Sack, Waterskin, etc.)	10	Specialized Tools (Ink, etc.)	20
Cooking Gear (Pots, Utensils, etc.)	10	Spiked Boots	15
Costume Gear (Face Paint, Disguise)	15	Spyglass	40
Dowsing Rod	15	Tent (fits 2, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Expeditionary Gear (Climbing Spikes, Pulley, etc.)	10	Thieving Tools (Lockpick, Metal File, etc.)	25
Fire Oil	10	Torch (3 uses)	5
Fishing Rod	10	Trap (d6 STR damage)	35
Games (Cards, Dice, etc.)	10	Whistle (<i>petty</i>)	15
		Wilderness Clothes (Poncho, Cloak, etc.) (<i>petty</i>)	15

Upkeep & Recovery

Room & Board (per night)	10
Private Room & Board (fits 4)	35
Stable & Feed (per night)	5
Medical Healing	50
Rations (3 uses)	10
Animal Feed (3 uses, <i>bulky</i>)	5

Hirelings

Alchemist	30
Animal Handler	5
Blacksmith	15
Bodyguard	10
Local Guide	5
Lockpick	10
Navigator	10
Sailor	5
Scholar	20
Tracker	5
Trapper	5
Veteran Bodyguard	20

Critical Damage

- Damage that reduces a target's HP below zero is subtracted from their STR by the amount of damage remaining. The target must then immediately make a STR save to avoid taking Critical Damage, using their new STR score. On a success, the target is still in the fight (albeit with a lower STR score) and must continue to make critical damage saves when incurring damage.
- Any PC that suffers Critical Damage cannot do anything but crawl weakly, grasping for life. If given aid (such as bandages), they will stabilize. If left untreated, they die within the hour. NPCs and monsters that fail a Critical Damage save are considered dead, per the Warden's discretion. Additionally, some enemies will have special abilities or effects that are triggered when their target fails a critical damage save.

Character Death

- When a character dies, the player should create a new character or take control of a hireling. They immediately join the party in order to reduce downtime.

Detachments

- Large groups of similar combatants fighting together are treated as a single Detachment. When a detachment takes Critical Damage, it is routed or significantly weakened. When it reaches 0 STR, it is destroyed.
- Attacks against detachments by individuals are *impaired* (excluding *blast* damage). Attacks against individuals by detachments are *enhanced* and deal *blast* damage.

Retreat

- Running away from a dire situation always requires a successful DEX save, as well as a safe destination to run to.

Morale

- Enemies must pass a WIL save to avoid fleeing when they take their first casualty and again when they lose half their number.
- Some groups may use their leader's WIL in place of their own. Lone foes must save when they're reduced to 0 HP.
- Morale does not affect PCs.

Ranged Attacks

- Ranged weapons can target any enemy near enough to see the whites of their eyes. Attacks against especially distant targets are *Impaired*.
- Ammunition is not tracked unless otherwise specified.

Scars

If damage to a PC would reduce their HP to exactly 0, look up the result on the table below based on the amount of HP lost in the attack. For example, if a PC went from 3 HP to 0 HP, they would look at entry #3 (Walloped).

HP Lost	Result
1	Lasting Scar: Roll 1d6. 1: Neck, 2: Hands, 3: Eye, 4: Chest, 5: Legs, 6: Ear. Roll 1d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
2	Rattling Blow: You're disoriented and shaken. Describe how you refocus. Roll 1d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
3	Walloped: You're sent flying and land flat on your face, winded. You are <i>deprived</i> until you rest for a few hours. Then, roll 1d6. Add that amount to your max HP.
4	Broken Limb: Roll 1d6. 1-2: Leg, 3-4: Arm, 5: Rib, 6: Skull. Once mended, roll 2d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
5	Diseased: You're afflicted with a gross, uncomfortable infection. When you get over it, roll 2d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.
6	Reorienting Head Wound: Roll 1d6. 1-2: STR, 3-4: DEX, 5-6: WIL. Roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your current attribute, take the new result.
7	Hamstrung: You can barely move until you get serious help and rest. After recovery, roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your max DEX, take the new result.
8	Deafened: You cannot hear anything until you find extraordinary aid. Regardless, make a WIL save. If you pass, increase your max WIL by 1d4.
9	Re-brained: Some hidden part of your psyche is knocked loose. Roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your max WIL, take the new result.
10	Sundered: An appendage is torn off, crippled, or useless. (The Warden will tell you which.) Then make a WIL save. If you pass, increase your max WIL by 1d6.
11	Mortal Wound: You are <i>deprived</i> and out of action. You die in one hour unless healed. Upon recovery, roll 2d6. Take the new result as your max HP.
12	Doomed: Death seemed ever so close, but somehow you survived. If your next save against critical damage is a fail, you die horribly. If you pass, roll 3d6. If the total is higher than your max HP, take the new result.

Marketplace

| All prices are in gold pieces

Armor

Shield (+1 Armor)	10
Helmet (+1 Armor)	10
Gambeson (+1 Armor)	15
Brigandine (1 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Chainmail (2 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)	40
Plate (3 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)	60

Weapons

Dagger, Cudgel, Sickle, Staff, etc. (d6 damage)	5
Spear, Sword, Mace, Axe, Flail, etc. (d8 damage)	10
Halberd, War Hammer, Long Sword, etc. (d10 damage, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Sling (d6 damage)	5
Bow (d6 damage, <i>bulky</i>)	20
Crossbow (d8 damage, <i>bulky</i>)	30

Transport

Cart (+4 slots, <i>bulky</i>)	30
Wagon (+8 slots, <i>slow</i>)	200
Horse (+4 slots)	75
Mule (+6 slots, <i>slow</i>)	30
Carriage Seat	5
Ship's Passage	10

Gear Packages

Fighter

- 3d6 Gold Pieces
- Jerky (3 uses, *petty*)
- Torches (3 uses)
- Bandages (3 uses)
- Rope
- Shield (+1 Armor)
- Gambeson (+1 Armor)
- Sword (d8)
- Throwing Dagger (d6)
- Dog Tags (*petty*)

Thief

- 3d6 Gold Pieces
- Rations (3 uses)
- Twin Folding Daggers (d6+d6)
- Bullseye Lantern
- Oil Can (6 uses)
- Caltrops
- Small Mirror
- Lockpick
- Grappling Hook
- Dark Hood (*petty*)
- Chalk (*petty*)

Magic-User

- 3d6 Gold Pieces
- Rations (3 uses)
- Staff (d6)
- Knife (d6)
- Spellbook: *Illuminate*
- Spellbook: *Sleep*
- Scroll of *Detect Magic* (*petty*)
- Parchment & Ink (3 uses)
- Robes (*petty*)

Cleric

- 3d6 Gold Pieces
- Rations (3 uses)
- Torches (3 uses)
- War Hammer (d10, *bulky*)
- Helmet (+1 Armor)
- Spellbook: *Cure Wounds*
- Bandages (3 uses)
- Bone Charm (*petty*, casts *Ward* once per day)

Procedures

Dungeon Exploration

The Basics

- The dungeon exploration cycle (see below) is divided into a series of Turns, Actions, and their consequences.
- On their turn, a character can move a distance equal to their torchlight's perimeter (about 40ft), and perform one action. Players can use their action to move up to three times that distance though that will increase the chance of triggering a roll on the Dungeon Events table.
- The Warden should present obvious information about an area and its dangers freely and at no cost. Moving quickly or without caution may increase the chance of encountering a wandering monster, springing a trap, or triggering a roll on the Dungeon Events table.

Although the term “dungeon” is used here, it can mean any dangerous locale (mansions, farmhouses, adventure site, etc).

Dungeon Exploration Cycle

1. The Warden describes the party's surroundings and any immediate dangers (combat, traps, surprises, etc.). The players then declare their character's intended movements and actions.
2. The Warden resolves the actions of each character simultaneously, along with any actions that are already in progress. Remember, the Die of Fate can be a useful tool whenever the Warden is in doubt!
3. The players record any loss of resources and any new conditions (i.e. item use, deprivation, etc). The cycle then begins again. If appropriate, the Warden should roll on the Dungeon Events table. Keep common sense in mind when interpreting the results!

Dungeon Events

Exploring a dungeon is always dangerous, and time must always be weighed against the risk of awakening the location's denizens, natural hazards, and worse.

When the party:

- Spends more than one dungeon cycle in a single room or location
- Moves quickly or haphazardly through a room
- Moves into a new area, level, or zone
- Creates a loud disturbance

Roll on the table below:

1d6	Dungeon Events Table	
1	Encounter	Roll on an encounter table. Possibly hostile. (See Reactions.)
2	Sign	A clue, spoor, track, abandoned lair, scent, victim, etc is discovered.
3	Environment	Surroundings shift or escalate. Water rises, ceilings collapse, a ritual nears completion, etc.
4	Loss	Torches are blown out, an ongoing spell fizzles, etc. The party must resolve the effect before moving on.
5	Exhaustion	The party must rest (triggering another roll on this table), add a Fatigue, or consume a ration.
6	Quiet	The party is left alone (and safe) for the time being.

Actions

- Actions are any non-passive activities, such as searching for traps, forcing open a door, listening for danger, disarming a trap, engaging an enemy in combat, casting a spell, dodging a trap, running away, resting, etc.
- Some actions have special rules (see below), while others may take multiple turns to complete.
- Loud or noticeable actions may also trigger an encounter with the dungeon's denizens.

Searching

- A character can spend a turn performing an exhaustive search of one object or location in an area, revealing any relevant hidden treasure, traps, secret doors, etc.
- Larger rooms and difficult or complex dungeon terrain may take a few turns to properly search.
- Searching a room first is a safer way to explore the dungeon, but it has a steep cost: time.

Resting

- A character can spend a turn resting to restore all HP.
- A light source and a safe location are required to rest. Present or oncoming danger makes rest impossible.
- Resting does not restore Fatigue, as it is impossible to safely Make Camp in a dungeon.

62	Pail	84	Signal Flag
63	Paint	85	Smokebomb
64	Parchment & Ink (3 uses)	86	Smoking Herbs (3 uses)
65	Perfume	87	Songbook
66	Pickaxe	88	Spiked Boots
67	Pipe	89	Spyglass
68	Pliers	90	Stylus
69	Poison	91	Tar
70	Pole (10ft)	92	Tent (fits 2, bulky)
71	Poncho (petty)	93	Tongs
72	Pulley	94	Trap (d6 STR damage)
73	Random Spellbook	95	Wagon (+8 slots, slow)
74	Rope (25ft)	96	Waterproof Bag
75	Sack	97	Whetstone
76	Saw	98	Whistle (petty)
77	Scissors	99	Wig
78	Scroll of Random Spellbook (petty)	100	Wolfsbane
79	Sealable Bottle		
80	Sedative		
81	Sewing Kit		
82	Sextant		
83	Shovel		

Additional Gear

1	Acid
2	Air Bladder
3	Alcohol
4	Antitoxin
5	Bandages (3 uses)
6	Bell
7	Bellows
8	Blanket
9	Boltcutters
10	Bowl
11	Cage
12	Caltrops
13	Candle (3 uses, dim)
14	Cards
15	Cart (+4 slots, <i>bulky</i>)
16	Chain (10ft)
17	Chalk (<i>petty</i>)
18	Chisel
19	Climbing Spikes
20	Cloak (<i>petty</i>)
21	Compass
22	Crowbar
23	Dice
24	Dowsing Rod
25	Explosive
26	Fan
27	Fiddle
28	Fire Oil
29	Fishing Rod
30	Flash Powder

31	Flour
32	Garrotte
33	Gloves (<i>petty</i>)
34	Glue
35	Goggles
36	Grappling Hook
37	Grease
38	Hammer
39	Hammock
40	Hand Drill
41	Honey
42	Hourglass
43	Incense
44	Ladder (10 ft, <i>bulky</i>)
45	Lantern
46	Leech (restores 1 STR, 3 uses)
47	Lens
48	Lock & Key
49	Lockpick
50	Lodestone
51	Lute
52	Magnifying Glass
53	Manacles
54	Marbles
55	Mask
56	Metal File
57	Mirror
58	Mugwort
59	Net
60	Oil Can (6 uses)
61	Oilskin Bag

Panic

- A character that is surrounded by enemies, enveloped by darkness, or facing their greatest fears may experience *panic*. A WIL save is typically required to avoid losing control and becoming *panicked*.
- A *panicked* character must make a WIL save to overcome their condition as an action on their turn.
- A *panicked* character has 0 HP, does not act in the first round of combat, and all of their attacks are *impaired*.

Dungeon Elements

Light

- Torches and other radial sources of light illuminate 40ft of dungeon and beyond that only a dim outline of objects. Torches last until they are put out by a character or their environment.
- A torch can be lit 3 times before permanently degrading. A lantern can be relit 6 times per oil can, but requires more inventory slots.
- Characters without a light source may suffer from *panic* until their situation is remedied.

Doors

- Doors and entryways may be locked, stuck, or blocked entirely. Characters can try to force a door open (or wedge it shut) using available resources (spikes, glue) or through raw ability.
- The party's marching order determines who is most impacted by whatever lies beyond a door.
- A character can detect, through careful observation (listening, smelling, etc.), signs of life and other hazards through nearby doors and walls.

Traps

- A cautious character should be presented with any and all information that would allow them the opportunity to avoid springing a trap. An unwitting character will trigger a trap according to the fiction, or otherwise will have a 2-in-6 chance.
- Traps can usually be detected by carefully searching a room.
- Damage from traps is taken from Attributes (usually STR or DEX) and not from HP. Armor can reduce damage, but only if applicable (e.g. a shield would not reduce damage from noxious gas).

Wilderness Exploration

Watches

- A day is divided into three watches, called morning, afternoon, and night.
- Each character can choose one Wilderness Action per watch.
- If the characters split up, each group is treated as an independent entity.

Points

- Potential destinations on a map are called points.
- One or more watches may be required to journey between two points on a map, depending on the path, terrain, weather, and party status.
- The party has a rough idea of the challenges involved to get to their destination, but rarely any specifics.

Travel Duration

Travel time in Cairn is counted in watches, divided into three eight-hour segments per day. However, as most parties elect to spend the third watch of the day resting, one can use “days” as a shorthand for travel time.

To determine the distance between two points, combine all penalties from the path, terrain, and weather difficulty tables, taking into account any changes to those elements along the route. For travel via waterways, refer to the surrounding terrain difficulty. For especially vast terrain, assign a penalty of up to +2 watches to the journey.

The weather, terrain, darkness, injured party members, and other obstacles can impact travel or even make it impossible! In some cases, the party may need to add Fatigue or expend resources in order to sustain their pace. Mounts, guides, and maps can increase the party’s travel speed or even negate certain penalties.

Path Difficulty

Path	Penalty	Odds of Getting Lost
Roads	None	None
Trails	+1 Watch	2-in-6
Wilderness	+2 Watches	3-in-6

Path Distance	Penalty
Short	+1 Watch
Medium	+2 Watches
Long	+3 Watches

91	Tax Collector: Parchment & Ink (3 uses), Sealable Bottle, Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
92	Thief: Caltrops, Grappling Hook, Lockpick
93	Tinker: Grease, Hammer, Pliers
94	Toll Keeper: Bell, Lock & Key, Waterproof Bag
95	Toymaker: Glue, Pliers, Scissors
96	Vagabond: Blanket, Poncho (<i>petty</i>), Rope (25 ft)
97	Vintner: Alcohol, Rope (25 ft), Sealable Bottle
98	Weaver: Perfume, Rope (25 ft), Scissors
99	Witch: Candle (3 uses, dim), Spellbook, Wolfsbane
100	Witchfinder: Rope (25 ft), Scroll of Random Spellbook (<i>petty</i>), Spyglass

Armor & Weapon

All PCs start with the following gear:

- 3d6 Gold Pieces
- Rations (3 uses)
- Torch (3 uses)

Additionally, roll on the following tables for your character’s armor, weapons, and additional gear:

Armor (D6)

1	None. Roll for Additional Gear
2	Shield (+1 Armor)
3	Helmet (+1 Armor)
4	Gambeson (+1 Armor)
5	Chainmail (2 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)
6	Plate (3 Armor, <i>bulky</i>)

Weapons (D6)

1	Dagger, Cudgel, Sickle, Staff, etc. (d6 damage)
2	Spear, Sword, Mace, Axe, Flail, etc. (d8 damage)
3	Halberd, War Hammer, Long Sword, etc. (d10 damage, <i>bulky</i>)
4	Sling (d6 damage)
5	Bow (d6 damage, <i>bulky</i>)
6	Crossbow (d8 damage, <i>bulky</i>)

60	Librarian: Candle (3 uses, dim), Parchment & Ink (3 uses), random Scroll (<i>petty</i>)
61	Locksmith: Lock & Key, Metal File, Pliers
62	Lumberjack: Rope (25 ft), Saw, Whetstone
63	Mason: Chisel, Fan, Hammer
64	Merchant: Random Additional Gear, Stylus, Wagon (+8 slots, slow)
65	Miller: Bowl, Flour, Rope (25 ft)
66	Miner: Lantern, Lodestone, Pickaxe
67	Monk: Candle (3 uses, dim), Cloak (<i>petty</i>), Songbook
68	Musician: Bowl, Fiddle, Songbook
69	Naturalist: Hammock, Rope (25ft), Spyglass
70	Navigator: Compass, Poncho (<i>petty</i>), Spyglass
71	Oil Collector: Lantern, Oil Can (6 uses), Sealable Bottle
72	Painter: Paint, Parchment & Ink (3 uses), Stylus
73	Peddler: Cart (+4 slots, <i>bulky</i>), Random Additional Gear, Sack
74	Philosopher: Chalk (<i>petty</i>), Parchment & Ink, Pipe
75	Physician: Antitoxin, Bandages (3 uses), Crowbar
76	Pilgrim: Blanket, Pole (10 ft), Poncho (<i>petty</i>)
77	Potter: Chisel, Pail, Tongs
78	Priest: Bandages (3 uses), Candle (3 uses, dim), Incense
79	Prospector: Lantern, Lodestone, Pickaxe
80	Rat Catcher: Sack, Trap, Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
81	Sailor: Hammock, Rope (50 ft), Spyglass
82	Scribe: Candle (3 uses, dim), Parchment & Ink (3 uses), Stylus
83	Shepherd: Cloak (<i>petty</i>), Rope (25 ft), Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
84	Smuggler: Lock & Key, Oilskin Bag, Rope (25 ft)
85	Soldier: Spiked Boots, Tent (fits 2, <i>bulky</i>), Whetstone
86	Spy: Disguise Kit, Garrotte, Mirror
87	Stablehand: Blanket, Rope (25ft), Shovel
88	Street Preacher: Bell, Parchment & Ink, Scroll of Random Spellbook (<i>petty</i>)
89	Tailor: Cloak (<i>petty</i>), Scissors, Sewing Kit
90	Tanner: Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Pliers, Tar

Terrain Difficulty

Difficulty	Terrain	Penalty	Factors
Easy	Plains, plateaus, valleys	none	Safe areas for rest, fellow travelers, good visibility
Tough	Forests, deserts, hills	+1 Watch	Wild animals, flooding, broken equipment, falling rocks, unsafe shelters, hunter's traps
Perilous	Mountains, jungles, swamp	+2 Watches	Quicksand, sucking mud, choking vines, unclean water, poisonous plants and animals, poor navigation

Weather

Each day, the Warden should roll on the weather table for the appropriate season. If the “Extreme” weather result is rolled twice in a row, the weather turns to “Catastrophic”. A squall becomes a hurricane, a storm floods the valley, etc.

Weather Type

d6	Spring	Summer	Fall	Winter
1	Nice	Nice	Fair	Fair
2	Fair	Nice	Fair	Unpleasant
3	Fair	Fair	Unpleasant	Inclement
4	Unpleasant	Unpleasant	Inclement	Inclement
5	Inclement	Inclement	Inclement	Extreme
6	Extreme	Extreme	Extreme	Extreme

Weather Difficulty

Weather	Effect	Examples
Nice	Favorable conditions for travel.	Clear skies, sunny
Fair	Favorable conditions for travel.	Overcast, breezy
Unpleasant	Add a Fatigue or add one watch to the journey.	Gusting winds, rain showers, sweltering heat, chill air
Inclement	Add a Fatigue or add +1 watch. Increase terrain Difficulty by a step.	Thunderstorms, lightning, rain, muddy ground
Extreme	Add a Fatigue and add +1 watch. Increase terrain Difficulty by a step.	Blizzards, freezing winds, flooding, mud slides
Catastrophic	Most parties cannot travel under these conditions.	Tornados, tidal waves, hurricane, volcanic eruption

Wilderness Exploration Cycle

- 1. The Warden describes the current point or region on the map and how the path, weather, terrain, or party status might affect travel speed. The party plots or adjusts a given course towards their destination.
- 2. Each party member chooses a single Wilderness Action. The Warden narrates the results and then rolls on the Wilderness Events table. The party responds to the results.
- 3. The players and the Warden record any loss of resources and new conditions (i.e. torch use, deprivation, etc), and the cycle repeats.

Wilderness Events

1d6 Wilderness Events		
1	Encounter	Roll on an encounter table for that terrain type or location. Don't forget to roll for NPC reactions if applicable.
2	Sign	The party discovers a clue, spoor, or indication of a nearby encounter, locality, hidden feature, or information about a nearby area.
3	Environment	A shift in weather or terrain.
4	Loss	The party is faced with a choice that costs them a resource (rations, tools, etc), time, or effort.
5	Exhaustion	The party encounters a barrier, forcing effort, care or delays. This might mean spending extra time (and an additional Wilderness Action) or adding Fatigue to the PC's inventory to represent their difficulties.
6	Discovery	The party finds food, treasure, or other useful resources. The Warden can instead choose to reveal the primary feature of the area.

29	Crypt Custodian:	Incense, Lantern, Oil Can (6 uses)
30	Cultist:	Incense, Mask, Scroll of Random Spellbook (<i>petty</i>)
31	Demolitionist:	Explosive, Goggles, Grease
32	Dowser:	Dowsing Rod, Sealable Bottle, Shovel
33	Duelist:	Cloak (<i>petty</i>), Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Whetstone
34	Entertainer:	Dice, Songbook, Wig
35	Executioner:	Mask, Rope (25 ft), Whetstone
36	Falconer:	Cage, Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
37	Farmer:	Rope (25 ft), Sack, Shovel
38	Fence:	Bolt Cutters, Random Additional Gear, Sack
39	Fisher:	Air Bladder, Fishing Rod, Net
40	Fletcher:	Sack, Trap, Whetstone
41	Gambler:	Alcohol, Cards, Dice
42	Gardener:	Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Sack, Shovel
43	Glassblower:	Goggles, Lens, Pliers
44	Gong Farmer:	Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Sack, Shovel
45	Gravedigger:	Alcohol, Ladder, Shovel
46	Guard:	Lantern, Manacles, Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
47	Herald:	Mask, Signal Flag, Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
48	Herbalist:	Antitoxin, Mugwort, Sack
49	Hermit:	Blanket, Pole (10 ft), Smoking Herbs (3 uses)
50	Highway Robber:	Grappling Hook, Rope (25 ft), Signal Flag
51	Hunter:	Trap, Rope (25 ft), Smoking Herbs (3 uses)
52	Illusionist:	Candle (3 uses, dim), Flash Powder, Mirror
53	Innkeeper:	Alcohol, Bandages (3 uses), Parchment & Ink (3 uses)
54	Jailer:	Chain (10ft), Manacles, Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
55	Jester:	Cards, Lute, Perfume
56	Jeweler:	Magnifying Glass, Pliers, Tongs
57	Knight:	Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Signal Flag, Whetstone
58	Lamplighter:	Ladder (10ft, <i>bulky</i>), Oil Can (6 uses), Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
59	Leech Collector:	Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Leech (restores 1 STR, 3 uses), Net

Background

Roll on the following table to determine your character's background and starting equipment:

1	Acolyte: Incense, Parchment & Ink (3 uses), random Spellbook
2	Acrobat: Pole (10ft), Rope (25ft), Smokebomb
3	Alchemist: Acid, Lens, Oilskin Bag
4	Apothecary: Antitoxin, Bandages (3 uses), Sealable Bottle
5	Assassin: Garrote, Mask, Poison
6	Astrologer: Candle (3 uses, dim), Marbles, Spyglass
7	Baker: Flour, Honey, Sealable Bottle
8	Barber-Surgeon: Bandages (3 uses), Scissors, Sedative
9	Barkeep: Alcohol, Sealable Bottle, Sedative
10	Beadle: Bell, Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
11	Beekeeper: Fire Oil, Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Honey
12	Bell Ringer: Gloves (<i>petty</i>), Rope (25 ft), Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
13	Bird Keeper: Cage, Net, Whistle (<i>petty</i>)
14	Blacksmith: Bellows, Hammer, Iron Tongs
15	Bookbinder: Glue, Parchment & Ink (3 uses), Sewing Kit
16	Bounty Hunter: Flash Powder, Manacles, Rope (25 ft)
17	Butcher: Pail, Saw, Whetstone
18	Carpenter: Hammer, Metal File, Saw
19	Cartographer: Compass, Parchment & Ink (3 uses), Sextant
20	Cartwright: Hand Drill, Pulley, Saw
21	Chandler: Candle (3 uses, dim), Honey, Perfume
22	Charlatan: Cards, Paint, Perfume
23	Chimney Sweep: Bellows, Climbing Spikes, Rope (25 ft)
24	Clockmaker: Magnifying Glass, Metal File, Pliers
25	Cobbler: Pliers, Sack, Sewing Kit
26	Cook: Flour, Pail, Smoking Herbs (3 uses)
27	Cooper: Hammer, Hand Drill, Saw
28	Courier: Bell, Compass, Parchment & Ink (3 uses)

Wilderness Elements

Night

- The party can choose to travel during the night and rest during the day, but night travel is far slower and more treacherous!
- Traveling at night is always more dangerous! The Warden should roll twice on the Wilderness Events table.
- Some terrain and weather may be easier to traverse at night (desert, for example). The Warden should balance these challenges along with any other.

Sleep

- The last watch of the day is typically reserved for the Make Camp action.
- Characters typically need to sleep each day. Anything beyond a minor interruption can negate or cancel the benefits of sleep.
- If the party skips the Make Camp action, they each add a Fatigue to their inventory and are deprived. Additionally, traveling when sleep-deprived raises the terrain Difficulty by a step (i.e. Easy becomes Tough).

Light

- Torches and other radial sources of light illuminate 40ft ahead of the party, but beyond that only provides a dim outline of objects.
- Characters without a light source may suffer from *panic* until their situation is remedied.
- Environmental conditions (sudden gusts of wind, dust, water, etc.) can easily blow out a torch.

Light Sources

- A torch can be lit 3 times before degrading.
- A lantern can be relit indefinitely but requires a separate oil can (6 uses).

Wilderness Actions

Travel

- Travel begins. Obvious locations, features, and terrain of nearby areas are revealed according to their distance. This action is typically taken by the entire party as one.
- The party rolls 1d6 to see if they get lost along the way. This risk can increase or decrease, depending on path Difficulty, maps, party skills, and guides.
- If lost, the party may need to spend a Wilderness Action to recover their way. Otherwise, the party reaches the next point along their route.
- Remember to compare the results of getting lost to the relevant path Difficulty.

Explore

- One or more party members search a large area, searching for hidden features, scouting ahead, or treading carefully.
- A Location (shelter, village, cave, etc.) or Feature (geyser, underground river, beached ship, etc.) is discovered.
- The Travel action is still required to leave the current area, even if it has been completely explored.

Supply

- One or more party members may hunt, fish, or forage for food, collecting 1d4 Rations (3 uses each). The chance of a greater bounty increases with each additional participant (e.g. 1d4 becomes 1d6, up to a maximum of 1d12).
- Relevant experience or equipment may also increase the bounty collected.
- The party may encounter homes and small villages, spending gold and a full watch to resupply.

Make Camp

- The party stops to set up camp in the wilds. Each party member (and their mounts) consumes a Ration.
- A lookout rotation is set so that the party can sleep unmolested. A smaller party may need to risk sleeping unguarded or switch off sleeping over multiple days.
- Party members that were able to rest remove all of Fatigue from their inventory.

Speech

1	Blunt	6	Gravelly
2	Booming	7	Precise
3	Cryptic	8	Squeaky
4	Droning	9	Stuttering
5	Formal	10	Whispery

Clothing

1	Antique	6	Frayed
2	Bloody	7	Frumpy
3	Elegant	8	Livery
4	Filthy	9	Rancid
5	Foreign	10	Soiled

Virtue

1	Ambitious	6	Honorable
2	Cautious	7	Humble
3	Courageous	8	Merciful
4	Disciplined	9	Serene
5	Gregarious	10	Tolerant

Vice

1	Aggressive	6	Lazy
2	Bitter	7	Nervous
3	Craven	8	Rude
4	Deceitful	9	Vain
5	Greedy	10	Vengeful

Traits (d10)

Roll on the following tables for your character's Traits.

Physique

1	Athletic	6	Scrawny
2	Brawny	7	Short
3	Flabby	8	Statuesque
4	Lanky	9	Stout
5	Rugged	10	Towering

Skin

1	Birthmarked	6	Soft
2	Marked	7	Tanned
3	Oily	8	Tattooed
4	Rosy	9	Weathered
5	Scarred	10	Webbed

Hair

1	Bald	6	Long
2	Braided	7	Luxurious
3	Curly	8	Oily
4	Filthy	9	Wavy
5	Frizzy	10	Wispy

Face

1	Bony	6	Perfect
2	Broken	7	Rakish
3	Chiseled	8	Sharp
4	Elongated	9	Square
5	Pale	10	Sunken

Downtime

Between game sessions, players can engage in a variety of activities such as research, following up on leads, improving skills, or building relationships. A PC is limited to one Downtime Action at a time. These actions cannot be undertaken in unsafe conditions or while a character is in recovery. A character cannot perform an action if it would put their safety at risk.

Milestones

For activities requiring multiple steps, the Warden assigns 1-5 Milestones for players to track progress. Each Milestone represents a comprehensive, non-interactive task. The Warden may present different strategies to achieve these goals, each with distinct Milestones. Depending on the unfolding events in the game, the Warden is also empowered to introduce new Milestones or discard existing ones.

Costs

PCs can complete individual Milestones by taking a Downtime Action and paying its respective Cost. If a character is unable to pay the Cost, they may have to find some other way to achieve their goal. A few examples of Cost:

- **Gold:** Direct payment of gold from a character's inventory.
- **Resources:** Non-monetary costs such as material goods, specific common items, and so on.
- **Reputation:** Betting on a character's renown, personality, presence, social connections, etc.
- **Loss:** Offering something specific and unique. A finger, a soul, a Relic, etc.

Some Costs can be reduced or disregarded through character skills, connections, or force of will. For example, a PC may have already acquired the necessary reputation to gain access to a renowned institution, and thus the cost is abated. On the other hand, another character may not be so lucky and must rely on their force of personality instead. In this case, the Warden should state the risk (a permanent ban on entry, a loss of reputation, etc.). The PC then makes a WIL save; on a success, the cost is either reduced or avoided entirely.

Downtime Actions

The following activities represent some of the most common Downtime Actions a player can choose. The Warden can also create custom actions based on the needs of play.

Research

A PC investigates a question about a bit of lost or forgotten lore, the location of a lost item, the whereabouts of an important NPC, and so on. To take this action, the player must have a clearly formulated question they’d like to answer and a Source of knowledge in the game world that their character can interact with. If the PC does not have a Source, then they can spend a Downtime Action trying to find one. There is no guarantee that they will be successful. Once a question is posed and an appropriate Source has been identified, the Warden should provide any Milestones and associated Costs.

Questions

As always, the question must come from an experience that occurred during play.

Examples:

- “Where is the Lost Temple of East Nipoor?”
- “Who in Fortune City might know how to crack an ancient vault?”
- “Where can I find the cure to curly sickness?”

Sources

A Source is a person, place, faction, or entity that holds either a part or whole answer that the character seeks. They can be NPCs, Factions, spirits, or even other PCs.

Examples:

- Kewr the Mouth, a frequent contact for the Conclave of Merchants. Despite their excellent relationship with this faction, asking for help in an illicit activity might come at a high cost.
- A Woodwose who makes his home deep in the Forest of Knives. The party encountered him in an earlier expedition and the meeting did not end well. Still, he is said to know the nature of every herb and their healing properties.
- The Temple of Puppets, a nomadic circus troupe who have travelled the known and unknown lands. The party assisted one of their members during the Rain of Fire, when even the creatures of the Wood were preparing to flee their homes. If anyone has heard of forgotten places, it’s them.

Training

A character can improve their skills with an item or ability, with clear narrative or mechanical results. They might be interested in dealing greater damage with a particular weapon, decreasing their chances of getting lost in rough weather, or

80	Selene	Rowanfield
81	Shade	Rybak
82	Silas	Sawyer
83	Sky	Shepherd
84	Soren	Shevchenko
85	Sparrow	Slater
86	Stellan	Smirnov
87	Stone	Sokolov
88	Storm	Tanner
89	Talon	Thatcher
90	Thistle	Tallow
91	Thorn	Vukovic
92	Thresh	Webb
93	Valen	Whitlock
94	Vesper	Wicklowe
95	Vex	Wightman
96	Willow	Wilkin
97	Winslow	Wright
98	Wisp	Wynne
99	Wren	Yarrow
100	Yarrow	Zidar

Attributes

- Roll 3d6 for each of your character’s Attributes (Strength (STR), Dexterity (DEX), and Willpower (WIL)), in order. You may then swap any two results.

Hit Protection

- Roll 1d6 to determine your PC’s starting Hit Protection (HP).

49	Kavi	Kvasnikov
50	Keir	Lethbridge
51	Leif	Llewellyn
52	Liora	Locke
53	Lucan	Lovett
54	Lyra	Lukanov
55	Lysander	Maddox
56	Marius	Malinov
57	Marlowe	Marinov
58	Milo	Markov
59	Moss	Mason
60	Nazira	Melnik
61	Neria	Mercer
62	Noa	Milner
63	Nyx	Morozov
64	Onyx	Novak
65	Orla	Obradov
66	Pan	O'Callaghan
67	Patch	O'Farrell
68	Perran	O'Leary
69	Quill	Osipov
70	Rain	Pavlenko
71	Reed	Pekar
72	River	Petrov
73	Robin	Pisarev
74	Rowan	Powell
75	Rune	Price
76	Rush	Radoslav
77	Rye	Reeve
78	Sable	Rogov
79	Sage	Romanov

learning to read the languages of the ancients. A PC might spend multiple Downtime Actions sparring with a particular weapon, improving their skills week by week. Or they may need to travel to the home of a distant sage, improving themselves through short but intense study.

The player must describe precisely what they'd like to improve and a Master whom they might train with. And of course, the character's inspiration to improve should come from an experience in play. The Warden should provide any Milestones and associated Costs.

Examples:

- **The Two-Handed Parry:** When fighting with one hand free, a PC's HP temporarily increases by 1d4. The party took on a hireling from the Cratered Lands, whose fighters emphasize avoiding enemy attacks. She has agreed to train anyone who can best her in hand to hand combat.
- **Herbology:** Given proper ingredients, a PC can create a Healing Salve (restores 4 STR) as a Downtime Action. After receiving care from an elderly herbalist in the Verdant Glades, the wounded PC asked to be trained in the healing arts. The Master has agreed, but asked that they collect three rare herbs before training can begin.
- **Troutmaster:** When taking the Supply Action, Rations gathered near cold freshwater sources increase by one step (e.g. 1d4 becomes 1d6). The party escorted a stranded naturalist from the famously dreadful Silver Wastes safely back to the city. As thanks, she has offered to train a PC to identify and capture a common lakefish that frequents colder waters.

Strengthening Ties

A character fosters a connection with an NPC or Faction in the game world. First, they must identify the entity with whom they wish to strengthen ties, as well as a specific intent (e.g., building trust, mending a friendship, seeking membership in a Faction, forming an alliance, and so on). The Warden then provides concrete measures (described as Milestones and Costs) that the PC can undertake to advance the relationship. With each completed Milestone, the Warden describes how the PC's relationship has grown or changed.

Examples:

- After returning from an unsuccessful delve into the Roots, a PC discovers that they'd unknowingly brought along a stowaway: an eyeless devourer, barely hatched. They decide to keep the creature and train it in secret.
- During a play session, a PC becomes friendly with an agent of the Order of the Helm. Impressed by the Order's values, the PC asks what the requirements are to join.
- An agent for a powerful faction dies during the Battle of Frogs while under the party's care. Now those responsible wish to provide redress, so that the party can once again perform tasks for that faction.

Character Creation

Overview

- 1. Roll for your character's first and last Name as well as Age (2d20+10).
- 2. Roll for your characters' Attributes and Hit Protection. (pg. 27)
- 3. Roll for your character's Traits. (pg. 28)
- 4. Roll for your character's Background and related items. (pg. 30)
- 5. Roll for your character's Weapon & Armor. (pg. 33)
- 6. Roll for an Additional Gear to complete your character's starting equipment. (pg. 34)
- 7. Purchase any additional items your character can afford from the Marketplace. (pg. 37)

Names

	Given Name	Family Name
1	Adair	Abbot
2	Alaric	Addyman
3	Alder	Ashwell
4	Amaris	Balfe
5	Anwen	Baxter
6	Arlo	Bevan
7	Ash	Beran
8	Aster	Blackwood
9	Ballad	Bowen
10	Barley	Brewer
11	Basil	Broder
12	Beatrix	Bukharin
13	Birch	Cadwallan
14	Bram	Carter
15	Briar	Cobb
16	Brook	Collier
17	Bryn	Cooper

18	Cai	Crowther
19	Callan	Dempsey
20	Carver	Dermody
21	Cedric	Domański
22	Cinder	Dymov
23	Cliff	Fairweather
24	Corin	Fedorov
25	Crow	Fletcher
26	Dain	Fuller
27	Darnel	Galen
28	Dax	Glinka
29	Dorian	Glover
30	Eira	Golubov
31	Elowen	Gradnik
32	Ember	Granger
33	Eon	Grobar
34	Evander	Halberg
35	Falcon	Harkin
36	Faris	Hlebar
37	Fern	Hromada
38	Finch	Horgan
39	Flint	Iliev
40	Freya	Ivanec
41	Gale	Joryn
42	Garen	Kamensk
43	Hazel	Kavanagh
44	Hemlock	Kovac
45	Idris	Kovalenko
46	Ivy	Kravec
47	Juniper	Krznar
48	Kael	Kuchar